as several other papers on quantum foundations—none of which visibly hampered his career, which took him from Texas to Caltech, and ultimately to Los Alamos.

The success of Zurek's papers convinced Zeh the time was right to start working on decoherence again. He took on a promising young student, Erich Joos, and wrote several papers with him on decoherence. But Zeh didn't want his dissent from Copenhagen to impact Joos. "A young man should not immediately ruin his career by talking about Everett," Zeh told Joos when they first started working together. "So we'll write this paper without ever mentioning that." Zeh deliberately avoided talking about Everett altogether for several years after Zurek's papers appeared, in a vain attempt to safeguard Joos's career. But despite the excellent work that Zeh, Joos, Zurek, and others were doing on decoherence, Zeh's colleagues in Heidelberg were still unconvinced that it was real physics—when they were aware of it at all. "[In 1990] I had the idea that I might suggest Joos for his habilitation [the 'second PhD' required in Germany for anyone lecturing at a university]," Zeh recalled. "I suggested that to some of the people who could have influenced that. Well, the answer was, 'What has he done?' I said 'Decoherence.' [They replied] 'Decoherence? What is that?' In 1990!"

Decoherence finally found a broader audience of physicists in 1991, when Zurek wrote an article on the subject for *Physics Today,* the magazine of the American Physical Society. But Zurek's article made some controversial statements about decoherence—in particular, it came close to implying that decoherence could solve the measurement problem single-handedly. "In spite of the profound nature of the difficulties, recent years have seen a growing consensus that progress is being made in dealing with the measurement problem," Zurek wrote. "Macroscopic systems are never isolated from their environments.… The resulting 'decoherence' cannot be ignored when one addresses the problem of the [collapse] of the quantum mechanical wave packet." And toward the end of the article, he stated bluntly that "decoherence destroys superpositions."

A flurry of letters to *Physics Today* pushed back on Zurek, pointing out that decoherence couldn't solve the measurement problem in the absence of an interpretation to go along with it. For a small object in a Schrödinger's cat–like superposition of states put in contact with its environment, decoherence wouldn't destroy the superposition—it would make it worse.